

Key Terms in I/DD Support Systems for State and National Leaders

State and national leaders should understand the history and meaning of common words used in services for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (I/DD). Since the 1960s, people have worked hard to make sure people with I/DD can live, work, play, and be part of their communities. Laws like the *Developmental Disabilities Assistance and Bill of Rights Act* (DD Act) and the *Americans with Disabilities Act* helped confirm that people with I/DD deserve respect and opportunities to contribute to society. Over time, the words we use to talk about I/DD have changed to focus on helping people live ordinary lives with the right support.



Below are important words leaders should know:

Accessible (Accessibility)

means that places, services, and information are easy for people with I/DD to enter, use, and understand. A setting or communication must work as well for people with I/DD as it does for everyone else. We create this by working together in a way that everyone can join, participate, and feel like they belong there.

Advocacy (Advocate, Advocates)

means people with I/DD, their families, and supporters speak up to support what is needed or fair. They give advice to states about programs the states run. They teach others about making services and opportunities better.

Fairness

refers to making sure people with I/DD have equal opportunities to get the same services and support as everyone else. This includes equal access to health, money, safety, and overall success.

Barrier

denotes problems or challenges that make it harder for people with I/DD to access their community. It also means it can be hard to get the services and support they need.

Competitive Employment

is when a person with I/DD has a job in the community. They work alongside co-workers who do not have disabilities. They get paid at least minimum wage. They also have chances to move up to higher-paying or better jobs over time.

Disability(ies)

is just another way for a person's mind or body to be. Disabilities can affect how someone sees, hears, thinks, learns, feels, moves, communicates, and/or interacts with others. People with disabilities might



need extra support, such as equipment like wheelchairs, hearing aids, or communication devices, help from other people, assistive technology, or accessible buildings and spaces. Without enough support, people with disabilities face more challenges. Our lives become easier when we have the right support.

Inclusion (Inclusive, Inclusivity)

refers to making sure people with I/DD can take part in activities, groups, and understand how things are done. Everyone feels welcome, respected, and valued, especially people who might be left out.

Integration (Integrated)

can mean a few different things for people with I/DD. First, it refers to making sure they have opportunities to take part and feel welcome in their community. An example is when someone with I/DD has a job working with people without disabilities. Second, integration means providing different kinds of support, like long-term care and medical services, to meet each person's needs. Third, it describes how Medicare and Medicaid can work together. When these programs combine, a person can get the best possible services and support they need to live full, included lives.

Mental Health

refers to how we think, feel, and act. It also affects how we deal with stress, get along with others, and make decisions. People with I/DD often face mental health challenges more than others.

Person/People-Centered (Care)

means putting a person's needs, choices, and goals first. It makes sure their voice is heard, and their choices matter in all parts of their services and support. This helps people with I/DD feel stronger and more in control of their lives.

Transitions of Care

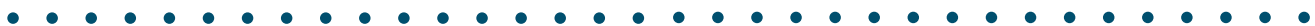
are when people with I/DD move from one service or place to another. This often happens at different times in their lives. For example, a young person with I/DD moving from school to a job. Another example is an adult with I/DD moving from an institution to a home in their community.

Trauma (Traumatic)

means a strong feeling of stress or fear. It happens when a person with I/DD experiences or remembers being hurt physically, emotionally, or mentally.



These words have a long history of importance for people with I/DD, their families, and the service delivery system. Understanding these terms helps leaders create better policies and support for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities.



This resource was created by The National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services (NASDDDS) in collaboration with Green Mountain Self-Advocates (GMSA). NASDDDS' goal is to promote and assist state agencies in developing effective, efficient service delivery systems that furnish high-quality supports to people with intellectual and developmental disabilities. The purpose of Green Mountain Self-Advocates (GMSA) is for people with developmental disabilities to educate peers to take control over their own lives, make decisions, solve problems, and speak for themselves. Another purpose of Green Mountain Self-Advocates is to educate and make the public aware of the strengths, rights, wants, and needs of people with developmental disabilities.

